

"Did he recommend stuff?" I wondered.

"Sometimes."

"And did you follow his recommendations?"

"Just as well you don't know. At least I've still got my car, still got my home. You know my ex-wife works down there?" He pointed to the floor of the stock exchange. "She had to get a job. I never see her anymore. She's down there now."

We stood together at the picture window and looked down to where Mr. Schwartz's ex-wife was supposed to be. Below us was the frantic spectacle of the most active marketplace for paper assets in the world. From the ornate walls and the decorated ceiling you'd think this was a nineteenth-century ballroom, cluttered with girders, tubes, and wires, as if a space station had fallen through the roof. Below the gridwork was a swirl of red, blue, and yellow coats, people hustling, people loitering, people queueing up at certain spots like would-be buyers at the ticket windows of sold-out Broadway shows.

A panel of recorded messages explained the scene: the runners and the messengers take buy and sell orders to the floor traders, the floor traders crowd around the specialists. The recorded message said that every share of stock is bought and sold through these lone individuals who stand there on the floor. Apparently, the small transactions are matched automatically by computer, but anything over 100 shares is handled through a specialist.

The specialist for IBM, for instance, buys all the IBM stock that sellers want to sell, then turns around and sells it to the buyers. The entire inventory of that billion-dollar issue is the exclusive franchise of a single vendor. Moreover, that same vendor must handle several other stocks, and there are 400 specialists, working at 14 posts for all the shares traded on the NYSE.

To me, this was an astounding setup. Each of the specialists must move millions of dollars of inventory every working day.

Above the specialists' posts are TV sets, across the floor a fantastic litter of crumpled messages, and the general din and clatter could be heard on our side of a thick picture window 50 feet beyond the action. A giant ticker tape runs its course along the ornate borders of the ballroom, and to the right of the tape is the platform where a bell is struck to start and stop the day's trading. I stood